



The Girl Who Drew the Revolution

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 Marjane Satrapi died in Paris on June 4, at fifty-six. She had drawn herself once as a small girl in a headscarf she did not want to wear, standing against a black panel, and that drawing went out into the world in thirty-three languages. The girl in the panel was angry and confused and ten years old. Readers in countries Satrapi had never seen knew exactly who she was.

2 Persepolis was not a grand book. It was small frames of black and white, a child watching her uncle taken away, a teenager sent alone to Vienna and sleeping for a stretch with nowhere to live. Satrapi published it in French in four thin volumes between 2000 and 2003, and Pantheon carried it into English soon after. By 2018 it had sold more than two million copies. Numbers like that usually belong to thrillers.

3 The book did one steady thing on every page. It refused to let a whole country become a headline. Where the news gave Iran a flag and a menace and a crowd, Satrapi gave it a grandmother, a maid, a cigarette smoked in secret, a Kim Wilde tape bought on a corner. Her great-grandfather had ruled that country as a Qajar shah in the nineteenth century, a fact she wore lightly, the way you might mention an old house in the family. The history was enormous. She kept drawing the small thing inside it.

4 When the animated Persepolis reached Cannes in 2007 it took the Jury Prize, and the Academy nomination that followed made her the first woman ever named in the animated feature category. She did not stay in one form. There was Embroideries, where Iranian women talk about sex and marriage over an afternoon. There was a live-action film, a dark Hollywood comedy with Ryan Reynolds, a feature about Marie Curie. She kept moving.

5 Her husband, the Swedish producer Mattias Ripa, died of cancer in April 2025, after thirty-one years. She entered a clinic in Munich this spring. Her family said she died of sadness, a little more than a year after he was gone. It is an unmedical word, and they used it anyway.

6 The girl in the black panel is still there, in two million copies, in thirty-three languages, on shelves in rooms Satrapi will never enter. She made one country legible to the rest by drawing it the size of a child. That child outlasts her now.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer contrasts how the news rendered Iran (a flag, a menace, a crowd) with what Satrapi rendered (a grandmother, a maid, a cigarette, a tape) primarily in order to
 - A) trace the chronological sequence of Satrapi's career
 - B) introduce the family history that the paragraph later mentions
 - C) define the particular work her drawings did against the abstraction of headlines
 - D) prove that news coverage of Iran was factually inaccurate
2. In the fifth paragraph, the short sentence calling sadness 'an unmedical word, and they used it anyway' best supports which characterization of the writer's tone toward the family's statement?
 - A) skeptical that grief could actually have caused her death
 - B) quietly respectful of a truth that exceeds clinical language
 - C) clinically detached from the question of how she died
 - D) openly grieving and unable to restrain emotion

Discussion questions:

1. The piece praises Persepolis for drawing a country 'the size of a child.' Where else in the opener does the writer make a large historical subject small and particular, and what does that scaling accomplish that a sweeping statement could not?
2. The final paragraph ends on the drawn girl rather than on Satrapi herself. Why might the writer choose to close on the work instead of the person, and how does that choice shape what the reader is left feeling?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a short tribute written after the death of the Iranian-French cartoonist and filmmaker Marjane Satrapi on June 4, 2026. Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay in which you analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to honor Satrapi and to convey the meaning of her work. In your response you should do the following: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence from the passage to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; demonstrate an understanding of the passage's rhetorical situation. Consider, among other choices, the writer's use of concrete imagery, the contrast between how the news depicted Iran and how Satrapi depicted it, the handling of the family's statement that she 'died of sadness,' and the decision to close on the drawn girl rather than on Satrapi herself.